

SETTLEPATH

Dog Independence Training Guide

Pen, another-room, home-departure and secure outdoor pathways - with graded starting levels from no alone time to one hour.

Website + installable app

Cloud-synced profiles, plan filtering and history-based recommendations.

Prepared July 2026

How to use this guide

SettlePath does not assume every dog uses a pen. The profile selects one of three setups: pen only, no pen, or both. No-pen users receive room-separation and home-departure plans; secure outdoor plans appear only when the user confirms that a suitable private outdoor area is available.

The initial recommendation uses the owner's estimate of the dog's present ability. Once sessions are saved, the latest trained plan becomes the baseline. Two calm scores of 4 or 5 on the same plan move up one step. Two scores of 1 or 2 move down one step. Mixed results, or any score of 3, repeat the same plan.

Choosing a route

Route	Use it when	Important note
Pen / enclosed area	The dog is already comfortable in a playpen, pen, crate-sized safe zone or gated enclosure.	Do not use confinement if it creates panic or escape attempts.
Room / home departures	The dog is calmer loose in a dog-safe room or gated part of the home.	Progress from visible barriers to room exits, departure cues and true front-door exits.
Secure outdoor practice	A private, escape-proof, weather-safe area is available and close monitoring is possible.	Outdoor work is optional and is not a substitute for learning calm home-alone time.

A dog who is distressed only when physically confined may need the room/home route rather than more pen training. Video comparison can help distinguish confinement distress from distress that occurs whenever the person leaves.

Profile and starting-level setup

A new dog profile records name, breed or mix, date of birth or approximate age, gender, pronouns, available training styles, secure outdoor availability, estimated current alone-time level and the route for the first recommendation.

Profile choice	First-plan behaviour
Cannot be left alone yet	SettlePath selects the nearest matching target in the preferred available route (foundation calmness).
Can be left for about 10 seconds	SettlePath selects the nearest matching target in the preferred available route (10 sec).
Can be left for about 30 seconds	SettlePath selects the nearest matching target in the preferred available route (30 sec).
Can be left for about 1 minute	SettlePath selects the nearest matching target in the preferred available route (1 min).
Can be left for about 5 minutes	SettlePath selects the nearest matching target in the preferred available route (5 min).
Can be left for about 10 minutes	SettlePath selects the nearest matching target in the preferred available route (10 min).
Can be left for about 20 minutes	SettlePath selects the nearest matching target in the preferred available route (20 min).
Can be left for about 30 minutes	SettlePath selects the nearest matching target in the preferred available route (30 min).
Can be left for about 45 minutes	SettlePath selects the nearest matching target in the preferred available route (45 min).
Can be left for about 60 minutes	SettlePath selects the nearest matching target in the preferred available route (1 hr).

Starting level is an estimate, not a test. Begin slightly easier when uncertain. For puppies and newly adopted dogs, sleep, toileting needs, settling-in time and previous experience can change performance from day to day.

Core training rules for every route

- Meet practical needs first: toilet, suitable exercise, rest, food and comfortable temperature.
- Use a genuinely dog-safe area and remove chewing, escape, poisoning and entanglement hazards.
- Begin below the point at which distress normally starts, then increase only one variable at a time.
- Use a camera or audio monitor for true departures whenever possible; hidden pacing, trembling or whining can otherwise be missed.
- Keep departures and returns calm. Do not punish barking, destruction or toileting that happened while the dog was alone.
- A timer is not a success if distress escalates. Record the longest comfortable duration.

Distress adjustment guide

Observation	Recommended response
Brief whine or one or two barks, then recovery	Reward the calm pause and make the next repetition easy.
Repeated vocalising but still taking food and pausing	Reduce duration or distance by about half.
Continuous sharper crying, frantic scratching, escape attempts or refusing food	Return calmly, end the challenge and move to a much easier plan.
Sudden difficulty after previous success	Check toileting, fatigue, pain, noise, temperature and other practical changes.

Outdoor independence: extra safety rules

Outdoor practice should be optional, short, closely monitored and limited to a private area that is reliably secure. It should not be used in unsafe heat, cold, storms, direct sun without shade, insecure fencing, theft-risk locations, or where the dog may repeatedly bark at neighbours, ingest hazards or escape.

- Confirm fencing, gates and latches before every practice.
- Provide clean water, shade and suitable shelter.
- Remove toxic plants, chemicals, tools, pools and chewable hazards.
- Use a camera or remain close enough to hear changes in behaviour.
- Do not use outdoor practice as punishment or as a way to ignore persistent barking.
- Move longer-duration independence work indoors unless the individual dog's welfare and environment are exceptionally suitable.

Complete graded plan directory

Pen / enclosed area

Stage	Plan	Target
Pen 1 of 26	Safe and Calm Beside the Pen	No absence
Pen 2 of 26	Small Distance Changes	No absence
Pen 3 of 26	Moving Around the Room	No absence
Pen 4 of 26	Extended Calm With You Nearby	No absence
Pen 5 of 26	The Distance Ladder	No absence
Pen 6 of 26	First Disappear-and-Reappear Practice	3 sec
Pen 7 of 26	Movement Plus First Absences	3 sec
Pen 8 of 26	Normal Household Activity	5 sec
Pen 9 of 26	Short Predictable Absences	10 sec
Pen 10 of 26	Mixed Short Absences	10 sec
Pen 11 of 26	Unpredictable Normal-Life Practice	15 sec
Pen 12 of 26	Bridge to 30 Seconds	20 sec
Pen 13 of 26	First Full 30 Seconds	30 sec
Pen 14 of 26	Steady 45-Second Absence	45 sec
Pen 15 of 26	One-Minute Independence	1 min
Pen 16 of 26	Ninety Seconds Out of Sight	1 min 30 sec
Pen 17 of 26	Two-Minute Calm	2 min
Pen 18 of 26	Three-Minute Routine	3 min
Pen 19 of 26	Five-Minute Independence	5 min
Pen 20 of 26	Eight-Minute Household Absence	8 min
Pen 21 of 26	Ten-Minute Calm Alone Time	10 min
Pen 22 of 26	Fifteen-Minute Independence	15 min
Pen 23 of 26	Twenty-Minute Independence	20 min
Pen 24 of 26	Thirty-Minute Independence	30 min
Pen 25 of 26	Forty-Five-Minute Independence	45 min
Pen 26 of 26	One-Hour Independence	1 hr

Room / home departures

Stage	Plan	Target
Home 1 of 18	Settle in a Chosen Safe Room	No absence
Home 2 of 18	Calm Behind a Baby Gate	10 sec
Home 3 of 18	First Room Exit and Return	10 sec
Home 4 of 18	Closed Door for 30 Seconds	30 sec

Stage	Plan	Target
Home 5 of 18	One Minute in Another Room	1 min
Home 6 of 18	Three-Minute Room Separation	3 min
Home 7 of 18	Five-Minute Room Routine	5 min
Home 8 of 18	Departure Cue Practice	No absence
Home 9 of 18	Front Door Exit for 10 Seconds	10 sec
Home 10 of 18	Front Door Exit for 30 Seconds	30 sec
Home 11 of 18	One Minute Outside the Home	1 min
Home 12 of 18	Three Minutes Outside the Home	3 min
Home 13 of 18	Five Minutes Outside the Home	5 min
Home 14 of 18	Ten Minutes Home Alone	10 min
Home 15 of 18	Twenty Minutes Home Alone	20 min
Home 16 of 18	Thirty Minutes Home Alone	30 min
Home 17 of 18	Forty-Five Minutes Home Alone	45 min
Home 18 of 18	One Hour Home Alone	1 hr

Secure outdoor practice

Stage	Plan	Target
Outdoor 1 of 8	Relax Outdoors While You Stay Visible	No absence
Outdoor 2 of 8	Step Indoors for 10 Seconds	10 sec
Outdoor 3 of 8	Thirty Seconds Outdoors Without You	30 sec
Outdoor 4 of 8	One Minute Secure Outdoor Practice	1 min
Outdoor 5 of 8	Three Minutes Secure Outdoor Practice	3 min
Outdoor 6 of 8	Five Minutes Secure Outdoor Practice	5 min
Outdoor 7 of 8	Ten Minutes Secure Outdoor Practice	10 min
Outdoor 8 of 8	Twenty Minutes Secure Outdoor Practice	20 min

Part 1: Pen and enclosed-area plans

Use the owner's selected profile to show only appropriate routes. Do not rush stages according to a calendar.

Safe and Calm Beside the Pen

Route: Pen / enclosed safe area **Target:** No planned absence

Best for: the dog still cries regularly, but can eat and settle when you stay close.

Goal: Teach them that the pen is safe even when you are present but not entertaining them.

Step	What to do	Reward / adjustment
Minute 1	Place the dog in the pen after a toilet break. Sit directly beside the pen, turned slightly sideways.	Drop 1 piece of kibble for any quiet pause, sniffing, sitting or looking away from you.
Minute 2	Remain beside the pen. Keep your hands to yourself and avoid eye contact.	Reward two or three calm moments. Do not reward every second.
Minute 3	Shift your chair or body about half a metre away.	If they stays quiet for 3-5 seconds, calmly place kibble into the pen.
Minute 4	Stay at the half-metre distance. Stand up once, then sit down again.	Reward after you sit if they remained calm or became quiet quickly.
Minute 5	Walk one step away and immediately return to your seat.	Reward a quiet pause after the movement. Make the next repetition smaller if barking increases.
Minute 6	Sit quietly and do something neutral, such as looking at a book or your phone.	Reward one or two settled behaviours, especially lying down or engaging with their toy.
Minute 7	Stand beside your chair for 5 seconds, then sit again.	Drop kibble only while they is quiet, even if the quiet pause lasts one second.
Minute 8	Take two slow steps away, pause briefly, then return to the chair.	Reward the first quiet moment after you return.
Minute 9	Return to sitting beside the pen and allow an easy minute.	Give one calm reward, then reduce food so they practises settling without constant feeding.
Minute 10	Finish with 20-30 seconds of calm beside the pen. Open the pen during a quiet pause.	Release them quietly. Avoid an excited greeting that makes leaving the pen the biggest reward.

Safety: Use the pen only as a positive safe area. Make sure it is large enough, comfortable, well ventilated and free of unsafe items. Do not continue while distress is escalating.

Success check: Repeat this level if the dog is mostly able to eat, pause, sniff, play or settle. Move down a level if the crying becomes continuous, sharper, frantic or difficult to interrupt.

Small Distance Changes

Route: Pen / enclosed safe area **Target:** No planned absence

Best for: the dog manages Level 1 with brief whining rather than escalating crying.

Goal: Help them cope while you move between beside the pen and a few steps away.

Step	What to do	Reward / adjustment
Minute 1	Start beside the pen for an easy success.	Reward the first calm pause.
Minute 2	Move one metre away and sit down.	Reward after 5-10 seconds of calm. Return to deliver the kibble, then move away again.
Minute 3	Alternate between sitting beside the pen and one metre away.	Reward calm transitions, not only lying down.
Minute 4	Stand up, take three slow steps, and return.	Reward a pause in crying. If they remained quiet, wait a little longer before rewarding.
Minute 5	Sit one to two metres away for the full minute.	Give one or two pieces of kibble during calm behaviour.
Minute 6	Walk past the pen once without stopping, then sit down farther away.	Reward after you are seated if they is calm.
Minute 7	Move closer for an easier repetition, but do not interact through the bars.	Reward relaxed body language or quiet engagement with a toy.
Minute 8	Move two metres away, stand for 5-10 seconds, then return to your chair.	Reward only after a quiet pause.
Minute 9	Sit at the easier distance and ignore them politely.	Allow them to discover that calmness does not always produce immediate attention.
Minute 10	End beside the pen, then release during a quiet moment.	Use one final piece of kibble inside the pen before opening it.

Safety: Use the pen only as a positive safe area. Make sure it is large enough, comfortable, well ventilated and free of unsafe items. Do not continue while distress is escalating.

Success check: Repeat this level if the dog is mostly able to eat, pause, sniff, play or settle. Move down a level if the crying becomes continuous, sharper, frantic or difficult to interrupt.

Moving Around the Room

Route: Pen / enclosed safe area **Target:** No planned absence

Best for: the dog can cope with you sitting one to two metres away.

Goal: Teach them that ordinary movement does not mean they must follow you.

Step	What to do	Reward / adjustment
Minute 1	Begin seated beside the pen for 30 seconds, then stand.	Reward one calm pause before moving.
Minute 2	Walk slowly around the room while remaining visible.	Approach and drop kibble after 10-15 seconds of calm.
Minute 3	Pick up or put down one harmless household item.	Reward calmness after the small noise or movement.
Minute 4	Sit across the room for 20-30 seconds, then stand again.	Reward only once during this minute unless they is finding it difficult.
Minute 5	Walk past the pen twice without stopping.	After the second pass, reward a quiet pause.
Minute 6	Pause near a doorway but remain fully visible.	Reward if they watches without escalating.
Minute 7	Return nearer for an easier minute and sit quietly.	Reward relaxed behaviour, then allow a short food-free period.
Minute 8	Walk to the far side of the room, pause for 5 seconds, and return.	Reward the first quiet moment after you return.
Minute 9	Repeat a mixture of sitting, standing and walking.	Use unpredictable rewards so they is not waiting for food after every movement.
Minute 10	Finish with an easy seated position. Release calmly.	Open the pen after 1-2 seconds of quiet if possible.

Safety: Use the pen only as a positive safe area. Make sure it is large enough, comfortable, well ventilated and free of unsafe items. Do not continue while distress is escalating.

Success check: Repeat this level if the dog is mostly able to eat, pause, sniff, play or settle. Move down a level if the crying becomes continuous, sharper, frantic or difficult to interrupt.

Extended Calm With You Nearby

Route: Pen / enclosed safe area **Target:** No planned absence

Best for: the dog can complete the easiest 10-minute sessions but is not ready for many disappearances.

Goal: Increase total session length without greatly increasing difficulty.

Step	What to do	Reward / adjustment
Minute 1	Settle the dog after toileting. Sit beside the pen.	Reward the first calm pause.
Minute 2	Remain beside them without eye contact or conversation.	Reward quiet sitting, sniffing or lying down.
Minute 3	Move half a metre away.	Reward after 5 seconds of calm.
Minute 4	Sit quietly and reduce food delivery.	One calm reward at most.
Minute 5	Stand, take one step away, and sit again.	Reward a quiet pause.
Minute 6	Move one metre away for 20-30 seconds.	Return to deliver kibble, then move away again.
Minute 7	Come closer for an easy recovery minute.	Reward settled behaviour.
Minute 8	Stand beside the pen without interacting.	Reward if they remains calm while you are upright.
Minute 9	Walk two slow steps away and return.	Reward after calmness.
Minute 10	Sit one metre away and look occupied.	Allow a food-free stretch.
Minute 11	Walk once around the room while visible.	Reward when you return to your chair.
Minute 12	Remain close for a recovery minute.	One small reward for calmness.
Minute 13	Move one metre away again.	Reward after a slightly longer quiet period.
Minute 14	Sit beside the pen but continue ignoring politely.	Do not make the ending obvious or exciting.
Minute 15	Give one final calm reward and release during quietness.	End neutrally.

Safety: Use the pen only as a positive safe area. Make sure it is large enough, comfortable, well ventilated and free of unsafe items. Do not continue while distress is escalating.

Success check: Repeat this level if the dog is mostly able to eat, pause, sniff, play or settle. Move down a level if the crying becomes continuous, sharper, frantic or difficult to interrupt.

The Distance Ladder

Route: Pen / enclosed safe area **Target:** No planned absence

Best for: the dog can stay calm with you nearby for 15 minutes.

Goal: Practise several distances while keeping you visible.

Step	What to do	Reward / adjustment
Minute 1	Start beside the pen.	Reward a calm start.
Minute 2	Move half a metre away.	Reward once.
Minute 3	Move one metre away.	Reward after 5-10 seconds of quiet.
Minute 4	Return closer for an easy minute.	Reward recovery.
Minute 5	Move two metres away and sit.	Reward once during calmness.
Minute 6	Stand at the same distance, then sit again.	Reward calm response to the change.
Minute 7	Walk across the room and return to the two-metre position.	Reward after you are seated.
Minute 8	Move beside the pen for recovery without interacting.	Minimal food.
Minute 9	Move to the far side of the room for 10-20 seconds.	Reward if manageable.
Minute 10	Walk past the pen without stopping.	Reward later, not immediately every time.
Minute 11	Sit two metres away and remain boring.	Allow a food-free settling period.
Minute 12	Move closer, then farther again.	Reward a calm transition.
Minute 13	Walk a small circle around the room.	Reward after a quiet pause.
Minute 14	Return to an easy distance.	One final calm reward.
Minute 15	Release quietly during a calm moment.	Avoid an excited greeting.

Safety: Use the pen only as a positive safe area. Make sure it is large enough, comfortable, well ventilated and free of unsafe items. Do not continue while distress is escalating.

Success check: Repeat this level if the dog is mostly able to eat, pause, sniff, play or settle. Move down a level if the crying becomes continuous, sharper, frantic or difficult to interrupt.

First Disappear-and-Reappear Practice

Route: Pen / enclosed safe area **Target:** 3 sec

Best for: the dog stays manageable while you walk around the room.

Goal: Introduce extremely short moments when you are out of sight.

Step	What to do	Reward / adjustment
Minute 1	Start beside the pen and reward calmness.	Give one easy success before any disappearance.
Minute 2	Walk around the room while remaining visible.	Reward once after a calm stretch.
Minute 3	Step partly behind the doorway for 1 second, then reappear.	Return calmly and reward a quiet pause. Repeat only two or three times.
Minute 4	Remain visible and sit one to two metres away.	Use this as a recovery minute. Reward once if calm.
Minute 5	Disappear for 1-2 seconds, reappear, then continue walking normally.	Reward after quietness; do not rush directly to the pen every time.
Minute 6	Do three easy visible movements.	Reward the easiest calm repetition.
Minute 7	Disappear for 2-3 seconds once or twice.	If they barks, wait for a tiny pause when safe, return, reward, and reduce the next absence.
Minute 8	Sit nearby without interaction.	Allow them to settle without constant food.
Minute 9	Mix one 1-second disappearance with visible walking.	Reward calmness unpredictably.
Minute 10	End with an easy visible minute and release calmly.	Finish before they becomes tired or frustrated.

Safety: Use the pen only as a positive safe area. Make sure it is large enough, comfortable, well ventilated and free of unsafe items. Do not continue while distress is escalating.

Success check: Repeat this level if the dog is mostly able to eat, pause, sniff, play or settle. Move down a level if the crying becomes continuous, sharper, frantic or difficult to interrupt.

Movement Plus First Absences

Route: Pen / enclosed safe area **Target:** 3 sec

Best for: the dog manages visible distance changes and some 1-3 second disappearances.

Goal: Blend normal movement with very brief out-of-sight repetitions.

Step	What to do	Reward / adjustment
Minute 1	Start beside the pen.	Reward calmness.
Minute 2	Walk slowly around the room.	Reward once.
Minute 3	Step out of sight for 1 second twice.	Reward a quiet pause after returning.
Minute 4	Sit one metre away for recovery.	One reward at most.
Minute 5	Complete a small visible household action.	Reward calmness after the movement.
Minute 6	Disappear for 2 seconds once or twice.	Reduce difficulty if barking escalates.
Minute 7	Remain visible and sit across the room.	Allow a food-free stretch.
Minute 8	Walk past the doorway but do not disappear.	Reward calm response to the cue.
Minute 9	Disappear for 2-3 seconds once.	Reward quietness after returning.
Minute 10	Come nearer for recovery without touching them.	Reward settled behaviour.
Minute 11	Walk around normally while visible.	One unpredictable reward.
Minute 12	Disappear for 1 second, then later for 3 seconds.	Keep both returns calm.
Minute 13	Sit one to two metres away.	Allow them to settle.
Minute 14	Finish with visible, easy movement.	Reward one calm moment.
Minute 15	Release quietly.	End before overtired crying begins.

Safety: Use the pen only as a positive safe area. Make sure it is large enough, comfortable, well ventilated and free of unsafe items. Do not continue while distress is escalating.

Success check: Repeat this level if the dog is mostly able to eat, pause, sniff, play or settle. Move down a level if the crying becomes continuous, sharper, frantic or difficult to interrupt.

Normal Household Activity

Route: Pen / enclosed safe area **Target:** 5 sec

Best for: the dog handles 1-3 second disappearances with only mild protest.

Goal: Make pen time feel like part of ordinary life rather than a formal exercise.

Step	What to do	Reward / adjustment
Minute 1	Settle them with a safe toy while you sit nearby.	Reward one calm start.
Minute 2	Walk around and complete a tiny household task.	Reward after 15-20 seconds of calm.
Minute 3	Disappear for 2-4 seconds, then return without making eye contact.	Reward a quiet pause after you are back.
Minute 4	Sit across the room and ignore them politely.	One calm reward at most.
Minute 5	Walk past the pen, touch the door handle, and remain visible.	Reward calmness around the departure cue.
Minute 6	Disappear for 3-5 seconds once or twice.	Reduce to 1-2 seconds if the crying becomes sharper or more continuous.
Minute 7	Return to visible movement and an easier distance.	Reward recovery and calm engagement with the toy.
Minute 8	Carry out another small normal task while visible.	Reward after a longer quiet stretch.
Minute 9	Mix one short disappearance with two easy visible movements.	Reward only one of the three repetitions.
Minute 10	Sit calmly near the pen, then release during quietness.	End neutrally, without a big reunion.

Safety: Use the pen only as a positive safe area. Make sure it is large enough, comfortable, well ventilated and free of unsafe items. Do not continue while distress is escalating.

Success check: Repeat this level if the dog is mostly able to eat, pause, sniff, play or settle. Move down a level if the crying becomes continuous, sharper, frantic or difficult to interrupt.

Short Predictable Absences

Route: Pen / enclosed safe area **Target:** 10 sec

Best for: the dog can recover quickly after 2-3 second disappearances.

Goal: Build absences of approximately 3-10 seconds while mixing in many easy repetitions.

Step	What to do	Reward / adjustment
Minute 1	Start close and easy.	Reward one calm pause.
Minute 2	Move around while visible.	Reward once.
Minute 3	Disappear for 3 seconds once.	Reward a quiet pause after returning.
Minute 4	Sit nearby for recovery.	Minimal food.
Minute 5	Disappear for 4-5 seconds once.	If they copes, reward calmly.
Minute 6	Complete two visible movements.	Reward one of them.
Minute 7	Disappear for 3 seconds, return, and remain visible.	Reward after calmness.
Minute 8	Sit farther away for a quiet minute.	Allow independent settling.
Minute 9	Disappear for 5-7 seconds once.	Halve the next absence if crying becomes continuous.
Minute 10	Come closer for recovery.	Reward calmness, not excitement.
Minute 11	Walk past the pen and touch the door handle.	Reward calm response to the cue.
Minute 12	Disappear for 3 seconds, then later for 6-8 seconds.	Keep the second repetition optional if they is tired.
Minute 13	Remain visible and boring.	No reward unless needed.
Minute 14	Finish with an easy visible minute.	One final calm reward.
Minute 15	Release during a quiet pause.	End neutrally.

Safety: Use the pen only as a positive safe area. Make sure it is large enough, comfortable, well ventilated and free of unsafe items. Do not continue while distress is escalating.

Success check: Repeat this level if the dog is mostly able to eat, pause, sniff, play or settle. Move down a level if the crying becomes continuous, sharper, frantic or difficult to interrupt.

Mixed Short Absences

Route: Pen / enclosed safe area **Target:** 10 sec

Best for: the dog usually settles quickly after 3-5 second absences.

Goal: Build flexibility with different distances and brief absences without making every repetition harder.

Step	What to do	Reward / adjustment
Minute 1	Start close and easy.	Reward the first calm pause.
Minute 2	Move around the room while visible.	Reward once.
Minute 3	Disappear for 3 seconds, then remain visible for the rest of the minute.	Reward calmness after returning.
Minute 4	Sit one metre away for an easy recovery minute.	Minimal food; encourage independent settling.
Minute 5	Disappear for 5-8 seconds once.	If calm, reward after returning. If they cries continuously, halve the next absence.
Minute 6	Complete two easy visible movements.	Reward one calm repetition.
Minute 7	Disappear for 3 seconds, return, then later disappear for 6-10 seconds.	Keep your return calm and ordinary.
Minute 8	Stay visible but farther away.	Reward a settled posture or quiet play.
Minute 9	Mix one easy 1-second absence and one harder 5-10 second absence.	Reward only after quietness; do not increase both distance and duration at once.
Minute 10	Finish close to the pen and release calmly.	End while they is still coping, not after a final difficult test.

Safety: Use the pen only as a positive safe area. Make sure it is large enough, comfortable, well ventilated and free of unsafe items. Do not continue while distress is escalating.

Success check: Repeat this level if the dog is mostly able to eat, pause, sniff, play or settle. Move down a level if the crying becomes continuous, sharper, frantic or difficult to interrupt.

Unpredictable Normal-Life Practice

Route: Pen / enclosed safe area **Target:** 15 sec

Best for: the dog manages 5-10 second absences without escalating.

Goal: Prevent them from predicting exactly when you leave, return or reward.

Step	What to do	Reward / adjustment
Minute 1	Start beside the pen and then move away.	Reward one calm start.
Minute 2	Perform a normal visible task.	Reward after a longer calm stretch.
Minute 3	Disappear for 5 seconds once.	Return calmly; reward quietness.
Minute 4	Sit across the room.	No reward unless they settles particularly well.
Minute 5	Walk past the pen twice without stopping.	Reward later, not immediately.
Minute 6	Disappear for 8-12 seconds once.	Reduce to 3-5 seconds if needed.
Minute 7	Return and continue the task rather than going directly to them.	Reward after they is quiet.
Minute 8	Sit nearby for recovery.	One small reward.
Minute 9	Disappear for 3 seconds, then remain visible.	Easy repetition.
Minute 10	Complete a quiet household task for the full minute.	Reward at the end if calm.
Minute 11	Disappear for 10-15 seconds once.	Only attempt if the previous minutes were manageable.
Minute 12	Return and sit one to two metres away.	Allow them to settle without immediate food.
Minute 13	Mix visible walking with one 5-second absence.	Reward unpredictably.
Minute 14	Finish close and calm.	One final reward inside the pen.
Minute 15	Release quietly during calmness.	No big reunion.

Safety: Use the pen only as a positive safe area. Make sure it is large enough, comfortable, well ventilated and free of unsafe items. Do not continue while distress is escalating.

Success check: Repeat this level if the dog is mostly able to eat, pause, sniff, play or settle. Move down a level if the crying becomes continuous, sharper, frantic or difficult to interrupt.

Bridge to 30 Seconds

Route: Pen / enclosed safe area **Target:** 20 sec

Best for: the dog usually recovers quickly after 10-15 second disappearances.

Goal: Practise flexible 10-20 second absences before beginning the dedicated 30-second ladder.

Step	What to do	Reward / adjustment
Minute 1	Begin close and easy.	Reward calmness.
Minute 2	Walk around while visible.	Reward once.
Minute 3	Disappear for 8-10 seconds.	Reward a quiet pause after returning.
Minute 4	Sit nearby for recovery.	Minimal food.
Minute 5	Disappear for 15-20 seconds once.	Return earlier if distress escalates.
Minute 6	Stay visible and perform an easy task.	Reward recovery.
Minute 7	Disappear for 5 seconds only.	This easier repetition prevents constant escalation.
Minute 8	Sit across the room for the full minute.	Allow independent settling.
Minute 9	Disappear for approximately 15-20 seconds once.	Attempt this only while they remains manageable; return earlier if crying escalates.
Minute 10	Return and remain visible.	Reward after quietness.
Minute 11	Complete two easy visible movements.	Reward one calm response.
Minute 12	Repeat an easier 8-12 second disappearance rather than adding a longer final test.	End with confidence. The next stage contains the first dedicated 30-second attempt.
Minute 13	Return and sit near the pen for recovery.	Give one calm reward.
Minute 14	Keep the final minute easy and visible.	Do not add a last difficult test.
Minute 15	Release quietly during calmness.	End while they is coping.

Safety: Use the pen only as a positive safe area. Make sure it is large enough, comfortable, well ventilated and free of unsafe items. Do not continue while distress is escalating.

Success check: Repeat this level if the dog is mostly able to eat, pause, sniff, play or settle. Move down a level if the crying becomes continuous, sharper, frantic or difficult to interrupt.

First Full 30 Seconds

Route: Pen / enclosed safe area **Target:** 30 sec

Best for: the dog has completed the 10-20 second bridge stage calmly on two separate attempts.

Goal: Build a comfortable, repeatable out-of-sight period of 30 sec without escalating distress.

Step	What to do	Reward / adjustment
Preparation	Give the dog a toilet opportunity, check that they is awake but not overtired, and place a safe familiar item in the pen.	Begin only when they can take food and their body language is manageable.
Visible warm-up (2 min)	Stay visible, move normally around the room, and reward one or two calm moments.	Keep this easy. The warm-up should lower tension, not test them.
Absence 1 (5 sec)	Disappear completely for about 5 sec, then reappear calmly.	Reward a quiet pause or settled behaviour after returning. Do not create an excited reunion.
Visible recovery (2 min)	Remain visible and complete a neutral household action while the dog settles again.	If they does not recover, stop here and repeat an easier stage next time.
Absence 2 (15 sec)	Disappear for approximately 15 sec, then return in the same quiet manner.	Reward calm recovery. If barking becomes sharper or continuous, shorten the challenge attempt.
Recovery and readiness check (2-3 min)	Stay visible. Continue only if the dog can settle, take food, and is not becoming progressively more vocal.	It is always acceptable to finish after the warm-ups and record the easier result.
Target absence (30 sec)	Leave the dog out of sight for the stage target of 30 sec. Use an audio or video monitor for the longer stages when available.	Return before manageable protest becomes escalating distress. The target is confidence, not completing a timer at any cost.
Calm return (3-5 min)	Reappear quietly, continue an ordinary task, and let the dog settle before ending the practice.	Record the calmness score honestly. Open the pen during a calm moment and keep the reunion neutral.

Safety: Use the pen only as a positive safe area. Make sure it is large enough, comfortable, well ventilated and free of unsafe items. Do not continue while distress is escalating.

Success check: Give this exact stage a calmness score of 4 or 5 on two completed attempts before upgrading. A score of 3 repeats the stage. Two scores of 1 or 2 on this stage mean return to an easier stage.

Steady 45-Second Absence

Route: Pen / enclosed safe area **Target:** 45 sec

Best for: the dog has completed the previous stage calmly on two separate attempts.

Goal: Build a comfortable, repeatable out-of-sight period of 45 sec without escalating distress.

Step	What to do	Reward / adjustment
Preparation	Give the dog a toilet opportunity, check that they is awake but not overtired, and place a safe familiar item in the pen.	Begin only when they can take food and their body language is manageable.
Visible warm-up (2 min)	Stay visible, move normally around the room, and reward one or two calm moments.	Keep this easy. The warm-up should lower tension, not test them.
Absence 1 (10 sec)	Disappear completely for about 10 sec, then reappear calmly.	Reward a quiet pause or settled behaviour after returning. Do not create an excited reunion.
Visible recovery (2 min)	Remain visible and complete a neutral household action while the dog settles again.	If they does not recover, stop here and repeat an easier stage next time.
Absence 2 (20 sec)	Disappear for approximately 20 sec, then return in the same quiet manner.	Reward calm recovery. If barking becomes sharper or continuous, shorten the challenge attempt.
Recovery and readiness check (2-3 min)	Stay visible. Continue only if the dog can settle, take food, and is not becoming progressively more vocal.	It is always acceptable to finish after the warm-ups and record the easier result.
Target absence (45 sec)	Leave the dog out of sight for the stage target of 45 sec. Use an audio or video monitor for the longer stages when available.	Return before manageable protest becomes escalating distress. The target is confidence, not completing a timer at any cost.
Calm return (3-5 min)	Reappear quietly, continue an ordinary task, and let the dog settle before ending the practice.	Record the calmness score honestly. Open the pen during a calm moment and keep the reunion neutral.

Safety: Use the pen only as a positive safe area. Make sure it is large enough, comfortable, well ventilated and free of unsafe items. Do not continue while distress is escalating.

Success check: Give this exact stage a calmness score of 4 or 5 on two completed attempts before upgrading. A score of 3 repeats the stage. Two scores of 1 or 2 on this stage mean return to an easier stage.

One-Minute Independence

Route: Pen / enclosed safe area **Target:** 1 min

Best for: the dog has completed the previous stage calmly on two separate attempts.

Goal: Build a comfortable, repeatable out-of-sight period of 1 min without escalating distress.

Step	What to do	Reward / adjustment
Preparation	Give the dog a toilet opportunity, check that they is awake but not overtired, and place a safe familiar item in the pen.	Begin only when they can take food and their body language is manageable.
Visible warm-up (2 min)	Stay visible, move normally around the room, and reward one or two calm moments.	Keep this easy. The warm-up should lower tension, not test them.
Absence 1 (15 sec)	Disappear completely for about 15 sec, then reappear calmly.	Reward a quiet pause or settled behaviour after returning. Do not create an excited reunion.
Visible recovery (2 min)	Remain visible and complete a neutral household action while the dog settles again.	If they does not recover, stop here and repeat an easier stage next time.
Absence 2 (30 sec)	Disappear for approximately 30 sec, then return in the same quiet manner.	Reward calm recovery. If barking becomes sharper or continuous, shorten the challenge attempt.
Recovery and readiness check (2-3 min)	Stay visible. Continue only if the dog can settle, take food, and is not becoming progressively more vocal.	It is always acceptable to finish after the warm-ups and record the easier result.
Target absence (1 min)	Leave the dog out of sight for the stage target of 1 min. Use an audio or video monitor for the longer stages when available.	Return before manageable protest becomes escalating distress. The target is confidence, not completing a timer at any cost.
Calm return (3-5 min)	Reappear quietly, continue an ordinary task, and let the dog settle before ending the practice.	Record the calmness score honestly. Open the pen during a calm moment and keep the reunion neutral.

Safety: Use the pen only as a positive safe area. Make sure it is large enough, comfortable, well ventilated and free of unsafe items. Do not continue while distress is escalating.

Success check: Give this exact stage a calmness score of 4 or 5 on two completed attempts before upgrading. A score of 3 repeats the stage. Two scores of 1 or 2 on this stage mean return to an easier stage.

Ninety Seconds Out of Sight

Route: Pen / enclosed safe area **Target:** 1 min 30 sec

Best for: the dog has completed the previous stage calmly on two separate attempts.

Goal: Build a comfortable, repeatable out-of-sight period of 1 min 30 sec without escalating distress.

Step	What to do	Reward / adjustment
Preparation	Give the dog a toilet opportunity, check that they is awake but not overtired, and place a safe familiar item in the pen.	Begin only when they can take food and their body language is manageable.
Visible warm-up (2 min)	Stay visible, move normally around the room, and reward one or two calm moments.	Keep this easy. The warm-up should lower tension, not test them.
Absence 1 (20 sec)	Disappear completely for about 20 sec, then reappear calmly.	Reward a quiet pause or settled behaviour after returning. Do not create an excited reunion.
Visible recovery (2 min)	Remain visible and complete a neutral household action while the dog settles again.	If they does not recover, stop here and repeat an easier stage next time.
Absence 2 (45 sec)	Disappear for approximately 45 sec, then return in the same quiet manner.	Reward calm recovery. If barking becomes sharper or continuous, shorten the challenge attempt.
Recovery and readiness check (2-3 min)	Stay visible. Continue only if the dog can settle, take food, and is not becoming progressively more vocal.	It is always acceptable to finish after the warm-ups and record the easier result.
Target absence (1 min 30 sec)	Leave the dog out of sight for the stage target of 1 min 30 sec. Use an audio or video monitor for the longer stages when available.	Return before manageable protest becomes escalating distress. The target is confidence, not completing a timer at any cost.
Calm return (3-5 min)	Reappear quietly, continue an ordinary task, and let the dog settle before ending the practice.	Record the calmness score honestly. Open the pen during a calm moment and keep the reunion neutral.

Safety: Use the pen only as a positive safe area. Make sure it is large enough, comfortable, well ventilated and free of unsafe items. Do not continue while distress is escalating.

Success check: Give this exact stage a calmness score of 4 or 5 on two completed attempts before upgrading. A score of 3 repeats the stage. Two scores of 1 or 2 on this stage mean return to an easier stage.

Two-Minute Calm

Route: Pen / enclosed safe area **Target:** 2 min

Best for: the dog has completed the previous stage calmly on two separate attempts.

Goal: Build a comfortable, repeatable out-of-sight period of 2 min without escalating distress.

Step	What to do	Reward / adjustment
Preparation	Give the dog a toilet opportunity, check that they is awake but not overtired, and place a safe familiar item in the pen.	Begin only when they can take food and their body language is manageable.
Visible warm-up (2 min)	Stay visible, move normally around the room, and reward one or two calm moments.	Keep this easy. The warm-up should lower tension, not test them.
Absence 1 (30 sec)	Disappear completely for about 30 sec, then reappear calmly.	Reward a quiet pause or settled behaviour after returning. Do not create an excited reunion.
Visible recovery (2 min)	Remain visible and complete a neutral household action while the dog settles again.	If they does not recover, stop here and repeat an easier stage next time.
Absence 2 (1 min)	Disappear for approximately 1 min, then return in the same quiet manner.	Reward calm recovery. If barking becomes sharper or continuous, shorten the challenge attempt.
Recovery and readiness check (2-3 min)	Stay visible. Continue only if the dog can settle, take food, and is not becoming progressively more vocal.	It is always acceptable to finish after the warm-ups and record the easier result.
Target absence (2 min)	Leave the dog out of sight for the stage target of 2 min. Use an audio or video monitor for the longer stages when available.	Return before manageable protest becomes escalating distress. The target is confidence, not completing a timer at any cost.
Calm return (3-5 min)	Reappear quietly, continue an ordinary task, and let the dog settle before ending the practice.	Record the calmness score honestly. Open the pen during a calm moment and keep the reunion neutral.

Safety: Use the pen only as a positive safe area. Make sure it is large enough, comfortable, well ventilated and free of unsafe items. Do not continue while distress is escalating.

Success check: Give this exact stage a calmness score of 4 or 5 on two completed attempts before upgrading. A score of 3 repeats the stage. Two scores of 1 or 2 on this stage mean return to an easier stage.

Three-Minute Routine

Route: Pen / enclosed safe area **Target:** 3 min

Best for: the dog has completed the previous stage calmly on two separate attempts.

Goal: Build a comfortable, repeatable out-of-sight period of 3 min without escalating distress.

Step	What to do	Reward / adjustment
Preparation	Give the dog a toilet opportunity, check that they is awake but not overtired, and place a safe familiar item in the pen.	Begin only when they can take food and their body language is manageable.
Visible warm-up (2 min)	Stay visible, move normally around the room, and reward one or two calm moments.	Keep this easy. The warm-up should lower tension, not test them.
Absence 1 (45 sec)	Disappear completely for about 45 sec, then reappear calmly.	Reward a quiet pause or settled behaviour after returning. Do not create an excited reunion.
Visible recovery (2 min)	Remain visible and complete a neutral household action while the dog settles again.	If they does not recover, stop here and repeat an easier stage next time.
Absence 2 (1 min 30 sec)	Disappear for approximately 1 min 30 sec, then return in the same quiet manner.	Reward calm recovery. If barking becomes sharper or continuous, shorten the challenge attempt.
Recovery and readiness check (2-3 min)	Stay visible. Continue only if the dog can settle, take food, and is not becoming progressively more vocal.	It is always acceptable to finish after the warm-ups and record the easier result.
Target absence (3 min)	Leave the dog out of sight for the stage target of 3 min. Use an audio or video monitor for the longer stages when available.	Return before manageable protest becomes escalating distress. The target is confidence, not completing a timer at any cost.
Calm return (3-5 min)	Reappear quietly, continue an ordinary task, and let the dog settle before ending the practice.	Record the calmness score honestly. Open the pen during a calm moment and keep the reunion neutral.

Safety: Use the pen only as a positive safe area. Make sure it is large enough, comfortable, well ventilated and free of unsafe items. Do not continue while distress is escalating.

Success check: Give this exact stage a calmness score of 4 or 5 on two completed attempts before upgrading. A score of 3 repeats the stage. Two scores of 1 or 2 on this stage mean return to an easier stage.

Five-Minute Independence

Route: Pen / enclosed safe area **Target:** 5 min

Best for: the dog has completed the previous stage calmly on two separate attempts.

Goal: Build a comfortable, repeatable out-of-sight period of 5 min without escalating distress.

Step	What to do	Reward / adjustment
Preparation	Give the dog a toilet opportunity, check that they is awake but not overtired, and place a safe familiar item in the pen.	Begin only when they can take food and their body language is manageable.
Visible warm-up (2 min)	Stay visible, move normally around the room, and reward one or two calm moments.	Keep this easy. The warm-up should lower tension, not test them.
Absence 1 (1 min)	Disappear completely for about 1 min, then reappear calmly.	Reward a quiet pause or settled behaviour after returning. Do not create an excited reunion.
Visible recovery (2 min)	Remain visible and complete a neutral household action while the dog settles again.	If they does not recover, stop here and repeat an easier stage next time.
Absence 2 (2 min)	Disappear for approximately 2 min, then return in the same quiet manner.	Reward calm recovery. If barking becomes sharper or continuous, shorten the challenge attempt.
Recovery and readiness check (2-3 min)	Stay visible. Continue only if the dog can settle, take food, and is not becoming progressively more vocal.	It is always acceptable to finish after the warm-ups and record the easier result.
Target absence (5 min)	Leave the dog out of sight for the stage target of 5 min. Use an audio or video monitor for the longer stages when available.	Return before manageable protest becomes escalating distress. The target is confidence, not completing a timer at any cost.
Calm return (3-5 min)	Reappear quietly, continue an ordinary task, and let the dog settle before ending the practice.	Record the calmness score honestly. Open the pen during a calm moment and keep the reunion neutral.

Safety: Use the pen only as a positive safe area. Make sure it is large enough, comfortable, well ventilated and free of unsafe items. Do not continue while distress is escalating.

Success check: Give this exact stage a calmness score of 4 or 5 on two completed attempts before upgrading. A score of 3 repeats the stage. Two scores of 1 or 2 on this stage mean return to an easier stage.

Eight-Minute Household Absence

Route: Pen / enclosed safe area **Target:** 8 min

Best for: the dog has completed the previous stage calmly on two separate attempts.

Goal: Build a comfortable, repeatable out-of-sight period of 8 min without escalating distress.

Step	What to do	Reward / adjustment
Preparation	Give the dog a toilet opportunity, check that they is awake but not overtired, and place a safe familiar item in the pen.	Begin only when they can take food and their body language is manageable.
Visible warm-up (2 min)	Stay visible, move normally around the room, and reward one or two calm moments.	Keep this easy. The warm-up should lower tension, not test them.
Absence 1 (1 min 30 sec)	Disappear completely for about 1 min 30 sec, then reappear calmly.	Reward a quiet pause or settled behaviour after returning. Do not create an excited reunion.
Visible recovery (2 min)	Remain visible and complete a neutral household action while the dog settles again.	If they does not recover, stop here and repeat an easier stage next time.
Absence 2 (3 min)	Disappear for approximately 3 min, then return in the same quiet manner.	Reward calm recovery. If barking becomes sharper or continuous, shorten the challenge attempt.
Recovery and readiness check (2-3 min)	Stay visible. Continue only if the dog can settle, take food, and is not becoming progressively more vocal.	It is always acceptable to finish after the warm-ups and record the easier result.
Target absence (8 min)	Leave the dog out of sight for the stage target of 8 min. Use an audio or video monitor for the longer stages when available.	Return before manageable protest becomes escalating distress. The target is confidence, not completing a timer at any cost.
Calm return (3-5 min)	Reappear quietly, continue an ordinary task, and let the dog settle before ending the practice.	Record the calmness score honestly. Open the pen during a calm moment and keep the reunion neutral.

Safety: Use the pen only as a positive safe area. Make sure it is large enough, comfortable, well ventilated and free of unsafe items. Do not continue while distress is escalating.

Success check: Give this exact stage a calmness score of 4 or 5 on two completed attempts before upgrading. A score of 3 repeats the stage. Two scores of 1 or 2 on this stage mean return to an easier stage.

Ten-Minute Calm Alone Time

Route: Pen / enclosed safe area **Target:** 10 min

Best for: the dog has completed the previous stage calmly on two separate attempts.

Goal: Build a comfortable, repeatable out-of-sight period of 10 min without escalating distress.

Step	What to do	Reward / adjustment
Preparation	Give the dog a toilet opportunity, check that they is awake but not overtired, and place a safe familiar item in the pen.	Begin only when they can take food and their body language is manageable.
Visible warm-up (2 min)	Stay visible, move normally around the room, and reward one or two calm moments.	Keep this easy. The warm-up should lower tension, not test them.
Absence 1 (2 min)	Disappear completely for about 2 min, then reappear calmly.	Reward a quiet pause or settled behaviour after returning. Do not create an excited reunion.
Visible recovery (2 min)	Remain visible and complete a neutral household action while the dog settles again.	If they does not recover, stop here and repeat an easier stage next time.
Absence 2 (5 min)	Disappear for approximately 5 min, then return in the same quiet manner.	Reward calm recovery. If barking becomes sharper or continuous, shorten the challenge attempt.
Recovery and readiness check (2-3 min)	Stay visible. Continue only if the dog can settle, take food, and is not becoming progressively more vocal.	It is always acceptable to finish after the warm-ups and record the easier result.
Target absence (10 min)	Leave the dog out of sight for the stage target of 10 min. Use an audio or video monitor for the longer stages when available.	Return before manageable protest becomes escalating distress. The target is confidence, not completing a timer at any cost.
Calm return (3-5 min)	Reappear quietly, continue an ordinary task, and let the dog settle before ending the practice.	Record the calmness score honestly. Open the pen during a calm moment and keep the reunion neutral.

Safety: Use the pen only as a positive safe area. Make sure it is large enough, comfortable, well ventilated and free of unsafe items. Do not continue while distress is escalating.

Success check: Give this exact stage a calmness score of 4 or 5 on two completed attempts before upgrading. A score of 3 repeats the stage. Two scores of 1 or 2 on this stage mean return to an easier stage.

Fifteen-Minute Independence

Route: Pen / enclosed safe area **Target:** 15 min

Best for: the dog has completed the previous stage calmly on two separate attempts.

Goal: Build a comfortable, repeatable out-of-sight period of 15 min without escalating distress. This is a longer future-stage attempt. Do only one full challenge attempt that day; other practices should be short, easy consolidation sessions.

Step	What to do	Reward / adjustment
Preparation	Give the dog a toilet opportunity, check that they is awake but not overtired, and place a safe familiar item in the pen.	Begin only when they can take food and their body language is manageable.
Visible warm-up (2 min)	Stay visible, move normally around the room, and reward one or two calm moments.	Keep this easy. The warm-up should lower tension, not test them.
Absence 1 (3 min)	Disappear completely for about 3 min, then reappear calmly.	Reward a quiet pause or settled behaviour after returning. Do not create an excited reunion.
Visible recovery (2 min)	Remain visible and complete a neutral household action while the dog settles again.	If they does not recover, stop here and repeat an easier stage next time.
Absence 2 (5 min)	Disappear for approximately 5 min, then return in the same quiet manner.	Reward calm recovery. If barking becomes sharper or continuous, shorten the challenge attempt.
Recovery and readiness check (2-3 min)	Stay visible. Continue only if the dog can settle, take food, and is not becoming progressively more vocal.	It is always acceptable to finish after the warm-ups and record the easier result.
Target absence (15 min)	Leave the dog out of sight for the stage target of 15 min. Use an audio or video monitor for the longer stages when available.	Return before manageable protest becomes escalating distress. The target is confidence, not completing a timer at any cost.
Calm return (3-5 min)	Reappear quietly, continue an ordinary task, and let the dog settle before ending the practice.	Record the calmness score honestly. Open the pen during a calm moment and keep the reunion neutral.

Safety: Use the pen only as a positive safe area. Make sure it is large enough, comfortable, well ventilated and free of unsafe items. Do not continue while distress is escalating.

Success check: Give this exact stage a calmness score of 4 or 5 on two completed attempts before upgrading. A score of 3 repeats the stage. Two scores of 1 or 2 on this stage mean return to an easier stage.

Twenty-Minute Independence

Route: Pen / enclosed safe area **Target:** 20 min

Best for: the dog has completed the previous stage calmly on two separate attempts.

Goal: Build a comfortable, repeatable out-of-sight period of 20 min without escalating distress. This is a longer future-stage attempt. Do only one full challenge attempt that day; other practices should be short, easy consolidation sessions.

Step	What to do	Reward / adjustment
Preparation	Give the dog a toilet opportunity, check that they is awake but not overtired, and place a safe familiar item in the pen.	Begin only when they can take food and their body language is manageable.
Visible warm-up (2 min)	Stay visible, move normally around the room, and reward one or two calm moments.	Keep this easy. The warm-up should lower tension, not test them.
Absence 1 (3 min)	Disappear completely for about 3 min, then reappear calmly.	Reward a quiet pause or settled behaviour after returning. Do not create an excited reunion.
Visible recovery (2 min)	Remain visible and complete a neutral household action while the dog settles again.	If they does not recover, stop here and repeat an easier stage next time.
Absence 2 (5 min)	Disappear for approximately 5 min, then return in the same quiet manner.	Reward calm recovery. If barking becomes sharper or continuous, shorten the challenge attempt.
Recovery and readiness check (2-3 min)	Stay visible. Continue only if the dog can settle, take food, and is not becoming progressively more vocal.	It is always acceptable to finish after the warm-ups and record the easier result.
Target absence (20 min)	Leave the dog out of sight for the stage target of 20 min. Use an audio or video monitor for the longer stages when available.	Return before manageable protest becomes escalating distress. The target is confidence, not completing a timer at any cost.
Calm return (3-5 min)	Reappear quietly, continue an ordinary task, and let the dog settle before ending the practice.	Record the calmness score honestly. Open the pen during a calm moment and keep the reunion neutral.

Safety: Use the pen only as a positive safe area. Make sure it is large enough, comfortable, well ventilated and free of unsafe items. Do not continue while distress is escalating.

Success check: Give this exact stage a calmness score of 4 or 5 on two completed attempts before upgrading. A score of 3 repeats the stage. Two scores of 1 or 2 on this stage mean return to an easier stage.

Thirty-Minute Independence

Route: Pen / enclosed safe area **Target:** 30 min

Best for: the dog has completed the previous stage calmly on two separate attempts.

Goal: Build a comfortable, repeatable out-of-sight period of 30 min without escalating distress. This is a longer future-stage attempt. Do only one full challenge attempt that day; other practices should be short, easy consolidation sessions.

Step	What to do	Reward / adjustment
Preparation	Give the dog a toilet opportunity, check that they is awake but not overtired, and place a safe familiar item in the pen.	Begin only when they can take food and their body language is manageable.
Visible warm-up (2 min)	Stay visible, move normally around the room, and reward one or two calm moments.	Keep this easy. The warm-up should lower tension, not test them.
Absence 1 (3 min)	Disappear completely for about 3 min, then reappear calmly.	Reward a quiet pause or settled behaviour after returning. Do not create an excited reunion.
Visible recovery (2 min)	Remain visible and complete a neutral household action while the dog settles again.	If they does not recover, stop here and repeat an easier stage next time.
Absence 2 (5 min)	Disappear for approximately 5 min, then return in the same quiet manner.	Reward calm recovery. If barking becomes sharper or continuous, shorten the challenge attempt.
Recovery and readiness check (2-3 min)	Stay visible. Continue only if the dog can settle, take food, and is not becoming progressively more vocal.	It is always acceptable to finish after the warm-ups and record the easier result.
Target absence (30 min)	Leave the dog out of sight for the stage target of 30 min. Use an audio or video monitor for the longer stages when available.	Return before manageable protest becomes escalating distress. The target is confidence, not completing a timer at any cost.
Calm return (3-5 min)	Reappear quietly, continue an ordinary task, and let the dog settle before ending the practice.	Record the calmness score honestly. Open the pen during a calm moment and keep the reunion neutral.

Safety: Use the pen only as a positive safe area. Make sure it is large enough, comfortable, well ventilated and free of unsafe items. Do not continue while distress is escalating.

Success check: Give this exact stage a calmness score of 4 or 5 on two completed attempts before upgrading. A score of 3 repeats the stage. Two scores of 1 or 2 on this stage mean return to an easier stage.

Forty-Five-Minute Independence

Route: Pen / enclosed safe area **Target:** 45 min

Best for: the dog has completed the previous stage calmly on two separate attempts.

Goal: Build a comfortable, repeatable out-of-sight period of 45 min without escalating distress. This is a longer future-stage attempt. Do only one full challenge attempt that day; other practices should be short, easy consolidation sessions.

Step	What to do	Reward / adjustment
Preparation	Give the dog a toilet opportunity, check that they is awake but not overtired, and place a safe familiar item in the pen.	Begin only when they can take food and their body language is manageable.
Visible warm-up (2 min)	Stay visible, move normally around the room, and reward one or two calm moments.	Keep this easy. The warm-up should lower tension, not test them.
Absence 1 (3 min)	Disappear completely for about 3 min, then reappear calmly.	Reward a quiet pause or settled behaviour after returning. Do not create an excited reunion.
Visible recovery (2 min)	Remain visible and complete a neutral household action while the dog settles again.	If they does not recover, stop here and repeat an easier stage next time.
Absence 2 (5 min)	Disappear for approximately 5 min, then return in the same quiet manner.	Reward calm recovery. If barking becomes sharper or continuous, shorten the challenge attempt.
Recovery and readiness check (2-3 min)	Stay visible. Continue only if the dog can settle, take food, and is not becoming progressively more vocal.	It is always acceptable to finish after the warm-ups and record the easier result.
Target absence (45 min)	Leave the dog out of sight for the stage target of 45 min. Use an audio or video monitor for the longer stages when available.	Return before manageable protest becomes escalating distress. The target is confidence, not completing a timer at any cost.
Calm return (3-5 min)	Reappear quietly, continue an ordinary task, and let the dog settle before ending the practice.	Record the calmness score honestly. Open the pen during a calm moment and keep the reunion neutral.

Safety: Use the pen only as a positive safe area. Make sure it is large enough, comfortable, well ventilated and free of unsafe items. Do not continue while distress is escalating.

Success check: Give this exact stage a calmness score of 4 or 5 on two completed attempts before upgrading. A score of 3 repeats the stage. Two scores of 1 or 2 on this stage mean return to an easier stage.

One-Hour Independence

Route: Pen / enclosed safe area **Target:** 1 hr

Best for: the dog has completed the previous stage calmly on two separate attempts.

Goal: Build a comfortable, repeatable out-of-sight period of 1 hr without escalating distress. This is a longer future-stage attempt. Do only one full challenge attempt that day; other practices should be short, easy consolidation sessions.

Step	What to do	Reward / adjustment
Preparation	Give the dog a toilet opportunity, check that they is awake but not overtired, and place a safe familiar item in the pen.	Begin only when they can take food and their body language is manageable.
Visible warm-up (2 min)	Stay visible, move normally around the room, and reward one or two calm moments.	Keep this easy. The warm-up should lower tension, not test them.
Absence 1 (3 min)	Disappear completely for about 3 min, then reappear calmly.	Reward a quiet pause or settled behaviour after returning. Do not create an excited reunion.
Visible recovery (2 min)	Remain visible and complete a neutral household action while the dog settles again.	If they does not recover, stop here and repeat an easier stage next time.
Absence 2 (5 min)	Disappear for approximately 5 min, then return in the same quiet manner.	Reward calm recovery. If barking becomes sharper or continuous, shorten the challenge attempt.
Recovery and readiness check (2-3 min)	Stay visible. Continue only if the dog can settle, take food, and is not becoming progressively more vocal.	It is always acceptable to finish after the warm-ups and record the easier result.
Target absence (1 hr)	Leave the dog out of sight for the stage target of 1 hr. Use an audio or video monitor for the longer stages when available.	Return before manageable protest becomes escalating distress. The target is confidence, not completing a timer at any cost.
Calm return (3-5 min)	Reappear quietly, continue an ordinary task, and let the dog settle before ending the practice.	Record the calmness score honestly. Open the pen during a calm moment and keep the reunion neutral.

Safety: Use the pen only as a positive safe area. Make sure it is large enough, comfortable, well ventilated and free of unsafe items. Do not continue while distress is escalating.

Success check: Give this exact stage a calmness score of 4 or 5 on two completed attempts before upgrading. A score of 3 repeats the stage. Two scores of 1 or 2 on this stage mean return to an easier stage.

Part 2: Room and home-departure plans

Use the owner's selected profile to show only appropriate routes. Do not rush stages according to a calendar.

Settle in a Chosen Safe Room

Route: Room / home departures **Target:** No planned absence

Best for: Cannot yet relax away from constant attention.

Goal: Build calm independence in the room that will later be used for alone time.

Step	What to do	Reward / adjustment
Step 1	Prepare Chosen dog-safe room while the person remains present: toilet break, comfortable resting place, water if appropriate, and one safe enrichment item.	Begin only when the dog is awake and reasonably calm.
Step 2	Stay nearby but become calmly unavailable. Read, work or complete a quiet task.	Reward relaxed behaviours such as sniffing, lying down or engaging with the enrichment item.
Step 3	Add small normal movements without leaving the area.	If vocalisation increases, reduce movement and reward the next calm pause.
Step 4	Finish after an easy calm period rather than after a final difficult test.	Keep the release or reunion low key.

Safety: Use a genuinely dog-safe room or area. Remove hazards, manage doors and windows, provide suitable temperature and water, and monitor for hidden distress.

Success check: Repeat until the dog remains mostly relaxed, can recover after small challenges and shows no escalating distress. Two calm scores of 4 or 5 move up one plan.

Calm Behind a Baby Gate

Route: Room / home departures **Target:** 10 sec

Best for: Can settle with the person nearby.

Goal: Introduce a visible barrier without fully disappearing.

Step	What to do	Reward / adjustment
Step 1	Prepare Room doorway with a secure baby gate: toilet break, safe resting place and a familiar enrichment item.	Do one easier warm-up repetition first.
Step 2	Complete three to six short repetitions. Move out of sight for up to 10 sec, then return calmly.	Return before panic. Reward calm recovery rather than excitement.
Step 3	After each challenge, include an easier visible or shorter repetition. Keep the dog within hearing range.	If distress grows, halve the next duration or return to the previous plan.
Step 4	End with a successful easy repetition and a neutral reunion.	Record the calmness score and the longest comfortable absence, not merely the timer reached.

Safety: Use a genuinely dog-safe room or area. Remove hazards, manage doors and windows, provide suitable temperature and water, and monitor for hidden distress.

Success check: Repeat until the dog remains mostly relaxed, can recover after small challenges and shows no escalating distress. Two calm scores of 4 or 5 move up one plan.

First Room Exit and Return

Route: Room / home departures **Target:** 10 sec

Best for: Can remain calm behind a gate for a few seconds.

Goal: Teach that a person can step out of the room and immediately return.

Step	What to do	Reward / adjustment
Step 1	Prepare Dog-safe room or gated area: toilet break, safe resting place and a familiar enrichment item.	Do one easier warm-up repetition first.
Step 2	Complete three to six short repetitions. Move out of sight for up to 10 sec, then return calmly.	Return before panic. Reward calm recovery rather than excitement.
Step 3	After each challenge, include an easier visible or shorter repetition. Keep the dog within hearing range.	If distress grows, halve the next duration or return to the previous plan.
Step 4	End with a successful easy repetition and a neutral reunion.	Record the calmness score and the longest comfortable absence, not merely the timer reached.

Safety: Use a genuinely dog-safe room or area. Remove hazards, manage doors and windows, provide suitable temperature and water, and monitor for hidden distress.

Success check: Repeat until the dog remains mostly relaxed, can recover after small challenges and shows no escalating distress. Two calm scores of 4 or 5 move up one plan.

Closed Door for 30 Seconds

Route: Room / home departures **Target:** 30 sec

Best for: Can cope with very short room exits.

Goal: Introduce a closed door in tiny, predictable repetitions.

Step	What to do	Reward / adjustment
Step 1	Prepare Dog-safe room with a closed door: toilet break, safe resting place and a familiar enrichment item.	Do one easier warm-up repetition first.
Step 2	Complete three to six short repetitions. Move out of sight for up to 30 sec, then return calmly.	Return before panic. Reward calm recovery rather than excitement.
Step 3	After each challenge, include an easier visible or shorter repetition. Keep the dog within hearing range.	If distress grows, halve the next duration or return to the previous plan.
Step 4	End with a successful easy repetition and a neutral reunion.	Record the calmness score and the longest comfortable absence, not merely the timer reached.

Safety: Use a genuinely dog-safe room or area. Remove hazards, manage doors and windows, provide suitable temperature and water, and monitor for hidden distress.

Success check: Repeat until the dog remains mostly relaxed, can recover after small challenges and shows no escalating distress. Two calm scores of 4 or 5 move up one plan.

One Minute in Another Room

Route: Room / home departures **Target:** 1 min

Best for: Recovers well after 30-second room separations.

Goal: Build a calm one-minute room separation.

Step	What to do	Reward / adjustment
Step 1	Prepare Dog-safe room: toilet break, safe resting place and a familiar enrichment item.	Do one easier warm-up repetition first.
Step 2	Complete two to four repetitions. Move out of sight for up to 1 min, then return calmly.	Return before panic. Reward calm recovery rather than excitement.
Step 3	After each challenge, include an easier visible or shorter repetition. Use a camera or audio monitor whenever possible.	If distress grows, halve the next duration or return to the previous plan.
Step 4	End with a successful easy repetition and a neutral reunion.	Record the calmness score and the longest comfortable absence, not merely the timer reached.

Safety: Use a genuinely dog-safe room or area. Remove hazards, manage doors and windows, provide suitable temperature and water, and monitor for hidden distress.

Success check: Repeat until the dog remains mostly relaxed, can recover after small challenges and shows no escalating distress. Two calm scores of 4 or 5 move up one plan.

Three-Minute Room Separation

Route: Room / home departures **Target:** 3 min

Best for: Can relax for about one minute.

Goal: Extend room separation while preserving easy recovery periods.

Step	What to do	Reward / adjustment
Step 1	Prepare Dog-safe room: toilet break, safe resting place and a familiar enrichment item.	Do one easier warm-up repetition first.
Step 2	Complete two to four repetitions. Move out of sight for up to 3 min, then return calmly.	Return before panic. Reward calm recovery rather than excitement.
Step 3	After each challenge, include an easier visible or shorter repetition. Use a camera or audio monitor whenever possible.	If distress grows, halve the next duration or return to the previous plan.
Step 4	End with a successful easy repetition and a neutral reunion.	Record the calmness score and the longest comfortable absence, not merely the timer reached.

Safety: Use a genuinely dog-safe room or area. Remove hazards, manage doors and windows, provide suitable temperature and water, and monitor for hidden distress.

Success check: Repeat until the dog remains mostly relaxed, can recover after small challenges and shows no escalating distress. Two calm scores of 4 or 5 move up one plan.

Five-Minute Room Routine

Route: Room / home departures **Target:** 5 min

Best for: Can cope for several minutes in another room.

Goal: Make short separation part of normal household life.

Step	What to do	Reward / adjustment
Step 1	Prepare Dog-safe room: toilet break, safe resting place and a familiar enrichment item.	Do one easier warm-up repetition first.
Step 2	Complete one or two planned attempts. Move out of sight for up to 5 min, then return calmly.	Return before panic. Reward calm recovery rather than excitement.
Step 3	After each challenge, include an easier visible or shorter repetition. Use a camera or audio monitor whenever possible.	If distress grows, halve the next duration or return to the previous plan.
Step 4	End with a successful easy repetition and a neutral reunion.	Record the calmness score and the longest comfortable absence, not merely the timer reached.

Safety: Use a genuinely dog-safe room or area. Remove hazards, manage doors and windows, provide suitable temperature and water, and monitor for hidden distress.

Success check: Repeat until the dog remains mostly relaxed, can recover after small challenges and shows no escalating distress. Two calm scores of 4 or 5 move up one plan.

Departure Cue Practice

Route: Room / home departures **Target:** No planned absence

Best for: Reacts to keys, shoes, bags or the front door.

Goal: Teach that departure cues do not always predict a long absence.

Step	What to do	Reward / adjustment
Step 1	Settle the dog in the chosen safe area with a familiar enrichment item.	Reward calmness before adding any departure cue.
Step 2	Pick up keys or a bag, walk briefly toward the exit, then put the item down without leaving.	Reward relaxed behaviour after the cue.
Step 3	Put on shoes or a jacket, touch and open the front door, then close it and resume a normal activity.	If the dog becomes tense, use a smaller cue such as touching the keys only.
Step 4	Mix several non-departure cue repetitions with one very easy room-separation repetition.	Finish when the dog is no longer predicting a long absence from every cue.

Safety: Use a genuinely dog-safe room or area. Remove hazards, manage doors and windows, provide suitable temperature and water, and monitor for hidden distress.

Success check: Repeat until the dog remains mostly relaxed, can recover after small challenges and shows no escalating distress. Two calm scores of 4 or 5 move up one plan.

Front Door Exit for 10 Seconds

Route: Room / home departures **Target:** 10 sec

Best for: Can remain in a safe room while the person moves around the home.

Goal: Introduce stepping outside the home for a few seconds.

Step	What to do	Reward / adjustment
Step 1	Prepare Dog-safe indoor area; person steps outside: toilet break, safe resting place and a familiar enrichment item.	Do one easier warm-up repetition first.
Step 2	Complete three to six short repetitions. Step through the exit, remain away for up to 10 sec, then return calmly.	Return before panic. Reward calm recovery rather than excitement.
Step 3	After each challenge, include an easier visible or shorter repetition. Keep the dog within hearing range.	If distress grows, halve the next duration or return to the previous plan.
Step 4	End with a successful easy repetition and a neutral reunion.	Record the calmness score and the longest comfortable absence, not merely the timer reached.

Safety: Use a genuinely dog-safe room or area. Remove hazards, manage doors and windows, provide suitable temperature and water, and monitor for hidden distress.

Success check: Repeat until the dog remains mostly relaxed, can recover after small challenges and shows no escalating distress. Two calm scores of 4 or 5 move up one plan.

Front Door Exit for 30 Seconds

Route: Room / home departures **Target:** 30 sec

Best for: Recovers easily after 10-second exits.

Goal: Build calm, repeated 30-second exits.

Step	What to do	Reward / adjustment
Step 1	Prepare Dog-safe indoor area; person exits the home: toilet break, safe resting place and a familiar enrichment item.	Do one easier warm-up repetition first.
Step 2	Complete three to six short repetitions. Step through the exit, remain away for up to 30 sec, then return calmly.	Return before panic. Reward calm recovery rather than excitement.
Step 3	After each challenge, include an easier visible or shorter repetition. Keep the dog within hearing range.	If distress grows, halve the next duration or return to the previous plan.
Step 4	End with a successful easy repetition and a neutral reunion.	Record the calmness score and the longest comfortable absence, not merely the timer reached.

Safety: Use a genuinely dog-safe room or area. Remove hazards, manage doors and windows, provide suitable temperature and water, and monitor for hidden distress.

Success check: Repeat until the dog remains mostly relaxed, can recover after small challenges and shows no escalating distress. Two calm scores of 4 or 5 move up one plan.

One Minute Outside the Home

Route: Room / home departures **Target:** 1 min

Best for: Can cope with short front-door exits.

Goal: Build one minute of true home-alone practice.

Step	What to do	Reward / adjustment
Step 1	Prepare Dog-safe indoor area; person outside the home: toilet break, safe resting place and a familiar enrichment item.	Do one easier warm-up repetition first.
Step 2	Complete two to four repetitions. Step through the exit, remain away for up to 1 min, then return calmly.	Return before panic. Reward calm recovery rather than excitement.
Step 3	After each challenge, include an easier visible or shorter repetition. Use a camera or audio monitor whenever possible.	If distress grows, halve the next duration or return to the previous plan.
Step 4	End with a successful easy repetition and a neutral reunion.	Record the calmness score and the longest comfortable absence, not merely the timer reached.

Safety: Use a genuinely dog-safe room or area. Remove hazards, manage doors and windows, provide suitable temperature and water, and monitor for hidden distress.

Success check: Repeat until the dog remains mostly relaxed, can recover after small challenges and shows no escalating distress. Two calm scores of 4 or 5 move up one plan.

Three Minutes Outside the Home

Route: Room / home departures **Target:** 3 min

Best for: Can stay calm for about one minute.

Goal: Extend true absence gradually to three minutes.

Step	What to do	Reward / adjustment
Step 1	Prepare Dog-safe indoor area; person outside the home: toilet break, safe resting place and a familiar enrichment item.	Do one easier warm-up repetition first.
Step 2	Complete two to four repetitions. Step through the exit, remain away for up to 3 min, then return calmly.	Return before panic. Reward calm recovery rather than excitement.
Step 3	After each challenge, include an easier visible or shorter repetition. Use a camera or audio monitor whenever possible.	If distress grows, halve the next duration or return to the previous plan.
Step 4	End with a successful easy repetition and a neutral reunion.	Record the calmness score and the longest comfortable absence, not merely the timer reached.

Safety: Use a genuinely dog-safe room or area. Remove hazards, manage doors and windows, provide suitable temperature and water, and monitor for hidden distress.

Success check: Repeat until the dog remains mostly relaxed, can recover after small challenges and shows no escalating distress. Two calm scores of 4 or 5 move up one plan.

Five Minutes Outside the Home

Route: Room / home departures **Target:** 5 min

Best for: Can relax during several short exits.

Goal: Build a reliable five-minute home-alone routine.

Step	What to do	Reward / adjustment
Step 1	Prepare Dog-safe indoor area; person outside the home: toilet break, safe resting place and a familiar enrichment item.	Do one easier warm-up repetition first.
Step 2	Complete one or two planned attempts. Step through the exit, remain away for up to 5 min, then return calmly.	Return before panic. Reward calm recovery rather than excitement.
Step 3	After each challenge, include an easier visible or shorter repetition. Use a camera or audio monitor whenever possible.	If distress grows, halve the next duration or return to the previous plan.
Step 4	End with a successful easy repetition and a neutral reunion.	Record the calmness score and the longest comfortable absence, not merely the timer reached.

Safety: Use a genuinely dog-safe room or area. Remove hazards, manage doors and windows, provide suitable temperature and water, and monitor for hidden distress.

Success check: Repeat until the dog remains mostly relaxed, can recover after small challenges and shows no escalating distress. Two calm scores of 4 or 5 move up one plan.

Ten Minutes Home Alone

Route: Room / home departures **Target:** 10 min

Best for: Can settle for about five minutes.

Goal: Reach ten minutes without increasing difficulty on every repetition.

Step	What to do	Reward / adjustment
Step 1	Prepare Dog-safe indoor area; monitored departure: toilet break, safe resting place and a familiar enrichment item.	Do one easier warm-up repetition first.
Step 2	Complete one or two planned attempts. Step through the exit, remain away for up to 10 min, then return calmly.	Return before panic. Reward calm recovery rather than excitement.
Step 3	After each challenge, include an easier visible or shorter repetition. Use a camera or audio monitor whenever possible.	If distress grows, halve the next duration or return to the previous plan.
Step 4	End with a successful easy repetition and a neutral reunion.	Record the calmness score and the longest comfortable absence, not merely the timer reached.

Safety: Use a genuinely dog-safe room or area. Remove hazards, manage doors and windows, provide suitable temperature and water, and monitor for hidden distress.

Success check: Repeat until the dog remains mostly relaxed, can recover after small challenges and shows no escalating distress. Two calm scores of 4 or 5 move up one plan.

Twenty Minutes Home Alone

Route: Room / home departures **Target:** 20 min

Best for: Can relax for ten minutes.

Goal: Extend to twenty minutes with one monitored challenge attempt.

Step	What to do	Reward / adjustment
Step 1	Prepare Dog-safe indoor area; monitored departure: toilet break, safe resting place and a familiar enrichment item.	Do one easier warm-up repetition first.
Step 2	Complete one monitored attempt. Step through the exit, remain away for up to 20 min, then return calmly.	Return before panic. Reward calm recovery rather than excitement.
Step 3	After each challenge, include an easier visible or shorter repetition. Use a camera or audio monitor whenever possible.	If distress grows, halve the next duration or return to the previous plan.
Step 4	End with a successful easy repetition and a neutral reunion.	Record the calmness score and the longest comfortable absence, not merely the timer reached.

Safety: Use a genuinely dog-safe room or area. Remove hazards, manage doors and windows, provide suitable temperature and water, and monitor for hidden distress.

Success check: Repeat until the dog remains mostly relaxed, can recover after small challenges and shows no escalating distress. Two calm scores of 4 or 5 move up one plan.

Thirty Minutes Home Alone

Route: Room / home departures **Target:** 30 min

Best for: Can remain settled for twenty minutes.

Goal: Build a stable half-hour routine.

Step	What to do	Reward / adjustment
Step 1	Prepare Dog-safe indoor area; monitored departure: toilet break, safe resting place and a familiar enrichment item.	Do one easier warm-up repetition first.
Step 2	Complete one monitored attempt. Step through the exit, remain away for up to 30 min, then return calmly.	Return before panic. Reward calm recovery rather than excitement.
Step 3	After each challenge, include an easier visible or shorter repetition. Use a camera or audio monitor whenever possible.	If distress grows, halve the next duration or return to the previous plan.
Step 4	End with a successful easy repetition and a neutral reunion.	Record the calmness score and the longest comfortable absence, not merely the timer reached.

Safety: Use a genuinely dog-safe room or area. Remove hazards, manage doors and windows, provide suitable temperature and water, and monitor for hidden distress.

Success check: Repeat until the dog remains mostly relaxed, can recover after small challenges and shows no escalating distress. Two calm scores of 4 or 5 move up one plan.

Forty-Five Minutes Home Alone

Route: Room / home departures **Target:** 45 min

Best for: Can cope reliably for thirty minutes.

Goal: Extend to forty-five minutes without rushing.

Step	What to do	Reward / adjustment
Step 1	Prepare Dog-safe indoor area; monitored departure: toilet break, safe resting place and a familiar enrichment item.	Do one easier warm-up repetition first.
Step 2	Complete one monitored attempt. Step through the exit, remain away for up to 45 min, then return calmly.	Return before panic. Reward calm recovery rather than excitement.
Step 3	After each challenge, include an easier visible or shorter repetition. Use a camera or audio monitor whenever possible.	If distress grows, halve the next duration or return to the previous plan.
Step 4	End with a successful easy repetition and a neutral reunion.	Record the calmness score and the longest comfortable absence, not merely the timer reached.

Safety: Use a genuinely dog-safe room or area. Remove hazards, manage doors and windows, provide suitable temperature and water, and monitor for hidden distress.

Success check: Repeat until the dog remains mostly relaxed, can recover after small challenges and shows no escalating distress. Two calm scores of 4 or 5 move up one plan.

One Hour Home Alone

Route: Room / home departures **Target:** 1 hr

Best for: Can remain relaxed for forty-five minutes.

Goal: Reach a future one-hour goal using calm, monitored practice.

Step	What to do	Reward / adjustment
Step 1	Prepare Dog-safe indoor area; monitored departure: toilet break, safe resting place and a familiar enrichment item.	Do one easier warm-up repetition first.
Step 2	Complete one monitored attempt. Step through the exit, remain away for up to 60 min, then return calmly.	Return before panic. Reward calm recovery rather than excitement.
Step 3	After each challenge, include an easier visible or shorter repetition. Use a camera or audio monitor whenever possible.	If distress grows, halve the next duration or return to the previous plan.
Step 4	End with a successful easy repetition and a neutral reunion.	Record the calmness score and the longest comfortable absence, not merely the timer reached.

Safety: Use a genuinely dog-safe room or area. Remove hazards, manage doors and windows, provide suitable temperature and water, and monitor for hidden distress.

Success check: Repeat until the dog remains mostly relaxed, can recover after small challenges and shows no escalating distress. Two calm scores of 4 or 5 move up one plan.

Part 3: Secure outdoor plans

Use the owner's selected profile to show only appropriate routes. Do not rush stages according to a calendar.

Relax Outdoors While You Stay Visible

Route: Secure outdoor practice **Target:** No planned absence

Best for: Is comfortable in a secure private outdoor area.

Goal: Teach calm settling outdoors without constant interaction.

Step	What to do	Reward / adjustment
Step 1	Prepare a fully secure, private, weather-safe outdoor area: toilet break, comfortable resting place, water if appropriate, and one safe enrichment item.	Begin only when the dog is awake and reasonably calm.
Step 2	Stay nearby but become calmly unavailable. Read, work or complete a quiet task.	Reward relaxed behaviours such as sniffing, lying down or engaging with the enrichment item.
Step 3	Add small normal movements without leaving the area.	If vocalisation increases, reduce movement and reward the next calm pause.
Step 4	Finish after an easy calm period rather than after a final difficult test.	Keep the release or reunion low key.

Safety: Do not use this route in unsafe heat, cold, storms, insecure fencing, theft-risk areas or where the dog may bark at neighbours, escape or access hazards. Keep water, shade and shelter available and monitor closely.

Success check: Use outdoor practice only when the dog remains physically safe and emotionally settled. Two calm scores of 4 or 5 move up one outdoor plan.

Step Indoors for 10 Seconds

Route: Secure outdoor practice **Target:** 10 sec

Best for: Can relax outside while the person is visible.

Goal: Introduce a very brief indoor disappearance.

Step	What to do	Reward / adjustment
Step 1	Prepare a fully secure, private, weather-safe outdoor area: toilet break, safe resting place and a familiar enrichment item.	Do one easier warm-up repetition first.
Step 2	Complete three to six short repetitions. Move indoors or out of view for up to 10 sec, then return to the secure outdoor area calmly.	Return before panic. Reward calm recovery rather than excitement.
Step 3	After each challenge, include an easier visible or shorter repetition. Keep the dog within hearing range.	If distress grows, halve the next duration or return to the previous plan.
Step 4	End with a successful easy repetition and a neutral reunion.	Record the calmness score and the longest comfortable absence, not merely the timer reached.

Safety: Do not use this route in unsafe heat, cold, storms, insecure fencing, theft-risk areas or where the dog may bark at neighbours, escape or access hazards. Keep water, shade and shelter available and monitor closely.

Success check: Use outdoor practice only when the dog remains physically safe and emotionally settled. Two calm scores of 4 or 5 move up one outdoor plan.

Thirty Seconds Outdoors Without You

Route: Secure outdoor practice **Target:** 30 sec

Best for: Recovers well after 10-second disappearances.

Goal: Build a calm 30-second outdoor separation.

Step	What to do	Reward / adjustment
Step 1	Prepare a fully secure, private, weather-safe outdoor area: toilet break, safe resting place and a familiar enrichment item.	Do one easier warm-up repetition first.
Step 2	Complete three to six short repetitions. Move indoors or out of view for up to 30 sec, then return to the secure outdoor area calmly.	Return before panic. Reward calm recovery rather than excitement.
Step 3	After each challenge, include an easier visible or shorter repetition. Keep the dog within hearing range.	If distress grows, halve the next duration or return to the previous plan.
Step 4	End with a successful easy repetition and a neutral reunion.	Record the calmness score and the longest comfortable absence, not merely the timer reached.

Safety: Do not use this route in unsafe heat, cold, storms, insecure fencing, theft-risk areas or where the dog may bark at neighbours, escape or access hazards. Keep water, shade and shelter available and monitor closely.

Success check: Use outdoor practice only when the dog remains physically safe and emotionally settled. Two calm scores of 4 or 5 move up one outdoor plan.

One Minute Secure Outdoor Practice

Route: Secure outdoor practice **Target:** 1 min

Best for: Can remain settled outside for 30 seconds.

Goal: Extend to one minute while monitored.

Step	What to do	Reward / adjustment
Step 1	Prepare a fully secure, private, weather-safe outdoor area: toilet break, safe resting place and a familiar enrichment item.	Do one easier warm-up repetition first.
Step 2	Complete two to four repetitions. Move indoors or out of view for up to 1 min, then return to the secure outdoor area calmly.	Return before panic. Reward calm recovery rather than excitement.
Step 3	After each challenge, include an easier visible or shorter repetition. Use a camera or audio monitor whenever possible.	If distress grows, halve the next duration or return to the previous plan.
Step 4	End with a successful easy repetition and a neutral reunion.	Record the calmness score and the longest comfortable absence, not merely the timer reached.

Safety: Do not use this route in unsafe heat, cold, storms, insecure fencing, theft-risk areas or where the dog may bark at neighbours, escape or access hazards. Keep water, shade and shelter available and monitor closely.

Success check: Use outdoor practice only when the dog remains physically safe and emotionally settled. Two calm scores of 4 or 5 move up one outdoor plan.

Three Minutes Secure Outdoor Practice

Route: Secure outdoor practice **Target:** 3 min

Best for: Can relax for one minute outdoors.

Goal: Build a three-minute outdoor separation.

Step	What to do	Reward / adjustment
Step 1	Prepare a fully secure, private, weather-safe outdoor area: toilet break, safe resting place and a familiar enrichment item.	Do one easier warm-up repetition first.
Step 2	Complete two to four repetitions. Move indoors or out of view for up to 3 min, then return to the secure outdoor area calmly.	Return before panic. Reward calm recovery rather than excitement.
Step 3	After each challenge, include an easier visible or shorter repetition. Use a camera or audio monitor whenever possible.	If distress grows, halve the next duration or return to the previous plan.
Step 4	End with a successful easy repetition and a neutral reunion.	Record the calmness score and the longest comfortable absence, not merely the timer reached.

Safety: Do not use this route in unsafe heat, cold, storms, insecure fencing, theft-risk areas or where the dog may bark at neighbours, escape or access hazards. Keep water, shade and shelter available and monitor closely.

Success check: Use outdoor practice only when the dog remains physically safe and emotionally settled. Two calm scores of 4 or 5 move up one outdoor plan.

Five Minutes Secure Outdoor Practice

Route: Secure outdoor practice **Target:** 5 min

Best for: Can settle outdoors for several minutes.

Goal: Reach five minutes without increasing difficulty too quickly.

Step	What to do	Reward / adjustment
Step 1	Prepare a fully secure, private, weather-safe outdoor area: toilet break, safe resting place and a familiar enrichment item.	Do one easier warm-up repetition first.
Step 2	Complete one or two planned attempts. Move indoors or out of view for up to 5 min, then return to the secure outdoor area calmly.	Return before panic. Reward calm recovery rather than excitement.
Step 3	After each challenge, include an easier visible or shorter repetition. Use a camera or audio monitor whenever possible.	If distress grows, halve the next duration or return to the previous plan.
Step 4	End with a successful easy repetition and a neutral reunion.	Record the calmness score and the longest comfortable absence, not merely the timer reached.

Safety: Do not use this route in unsafe heat, cold, storms, insecure fencing, theft-risk areas or where the dog may bark at neighbours, escape or access hazards. Keep water, shade and shelter available and monitor closely.

Success check: Use outdoor practice only when the dog remains physically safe and emotionally settled. Two calm scores of 4 or 5 move up one outdoor plan.

Ten Minutes Secure Outdoor Practice

Route: Secure outdoor practice **Target:** 10 min

Best for: Can remain calm for five minutes outdoors.

Goal: Build a monitored ten-minute outdoor routine.

Step	What to do	Reward / adjustment
Step 1	Prepare a fully secure, private, weather-safe outdoor area: toilet break, safe resting place and a familiar enrichment item.	Do one easier warm-up repetition first.
Step 2	Complete one or two planned attempts. Move indoors or out of view for up to 10 min, then return to the secure outdoor area calmly.	Return before panic. Reward calm recovery rather than excitement.
Step 3	After each challenge, include an easier visible or shorter repetition. Use a camera or audio monitor whenever possible.	If distress grows, halve the next duration or return to the previous plan.
Step 4	End with a successful easy repetition and a neutral reunion.	Record the calmness score and the longest comfortable absence, not merely the timer reached.

Safety: Do not use this route in unsafe heat, cold, storms, insecure fencing, theft-risk areas or where the dog may bark at neighbours, escape or access hazards. Keep water, shade and shelter available and monitor closely.

Success check: Use outdoor practice only when the dog remains physically safe and emotionally settled. Two calm scores of 4 or 5 move up one outdoor plan.

Twenty Minutes Secure Outdoor Practice

Route: Secure outdoor practice **Target:** 20 min

Best for: Can remain calm for ten minutes and the environment is exceptionally safe.

Goal: Use a future twenty-minute outdoor goal only when weather, security and supervision are suitable.

Step	What to do	Reward / adjustment
Step 1	Prepare a fully secure, private, weather-safe outdoor area: toilet break, safe resting place and a familiar enrichment item.	Do one easier warm-up repetition first.
Step 2	Complete one monitored attempt. Move indoors or out of view for up to 20 min, then return to the secure outdoor area calmly.	Return before panic. Reward calm recovery rather than excitement.
Step 3	After each challenge, include an easier visible or shorter repetition. Use a camera or audio monitor whenever possible.	If distress grows, halve the next duration or return to the previous plan.
Step 4	End with a successful easy repetition and a neutral reunion.	Record the calmness score and the longest comfortable absence, not merely the timer reached.

Safety: Do not use this route in unsafe heat, cold, storms, insecure fencing, theft-risk areas or where the dog may bark at neighbours, escape or access hazards. Keep water, shade and shelter available and monitor closely.

Success check: Use outdoor practice only when the dog remains physically safe and emotionally settled. Two calm scores of 4 or 5 move up one outdoor plan.

Using SettlePath as a website and app

The supplied code is a progressive web app (PWA). It remains a normal GitHub Pages website, but supported mobile browsers can install it to the home screen. The installed app uses the same Supabase account and data.

Installation

- Upload all supplied files, including manifest.webmanifest, service-worker.js and both icon files.
- Open the live HTTPS GitHub Pages website.
- Use the in-app Install app button when shown, or the browser's Add to Home screen / Install app menu.
- Sign in with the same username and password on each device to access the same cloud data.

Important

The app shell can be cached, but Supabase login and cloud synchronisation require an internet connection. The service worker uses network-first loading for HTML, CSS, JavaScript and the Supabase configuration so updates are less likely to remain stuck in an old cache.

When to seek professional help

Contact a veterinarian or qualified clinical animal behaviour professional when the dog panics rapidly, injures themselves, repeatedly attempts to escape, destroys doors or windows, drools heavily, toilets from distress, cannot eat when alone, or fails to progress despite careful sub-threshold training.

Do not repeatedly test a duration that reliably produces panic. Severe separation-related behaviour is not a basic obedience problem and may require an individual management and treatment plan.

Evidence-informed sources

The plans are an educational progression tool, not a diagnosis or substitute for individual veterinary or behaviour advice.

1. Dogs Trust - How to help your dog get used to spending time alone

Gradual in-home separation, baby gates, positive enrichment and shortening duration when anxiety appears.

<https://www.dogtrust.org.uk/dog-advice/training/home/time-alone>

2. RSPCA - How to train your dog to stay home alone

Gradual alone-time training, special enrichment and periodic video monitoring for hidden distress.

<https://www.rspca.org.uk/adviceandwelfare/pets/dogs/training/leftalone>

3. Blue Cross - Home alone and separation anxiety

Choosing a safe room, gradual time increases and recognising distress.

<https://www.bluecross.org.uk/advice/dog/home-alone-separation-anxiety-in-dogs>

4. AVSAB - Separation anxiety and confinement anxiety

Video can help distinguish confinement anxiety from distress that occurs whenever the dog is alone.

<https://avsab.org/separation-anxiety-the-great-imitator-part-1-2-copy/>

5. RSPCA - Keeping dogs outside

Outdoor safety requires shelter, water and protection from weather; dogs should not be left to become lonely or distressed.

<https://www.rspca.org.uk/adviceandwelfare/pets/dogs/environment/livingoutside>